senior told INDIA TODAY. The fact that they chose the path of an internal rebellion—always insisting that they *were* the real Sena, doubled the advantage. As the BJP's master strategists plotted their moves, the best possible route to a comprehensive checkmate suggested itself. That's what has borne fruit now.

THE ASTRAY THACKERAY

A mood altogether different from the present one of gloom had suffused the air as Uddhav took office in November 2019. His claim that the BJP ditched him on the promise of a rotating CM's chair had found resonance, partly soothing cadre discomfort over his ideological adventurism in joining up with the NCP-Congress. When he entered the six-storeyed Mantralaya for the first time to assume charge, hundreds of employees stood agog in all the corridors, stairways and elevators to get a glimpse of the first Thackeray to ever become CM. The name itself sufficed to tap into that emotional connect the average Marathi *manoos* has with the family. Uddhav had, after all, steered the Sena legacy and kept it intact after Balasaheb's death on November 17, 2012. The atmosphere was charged, yet overall the public mood seemed positive.

But the seeds of discord already resided in that moment. Loyal Sainiks partook of Uddhav's anger against the BJP, but found it difficult to entirely digest the new tie-up with parties they had spent their lives fighting on the street. Their hands tied, frustration brewed in their minds—and Uddhav's aloofness brought no scope for the allaying of their doubts. Indeed, his claim that it was NCP chief Sharad Pawar who made him accept the CM's post actually widened his distance from the psychology of the grassroots worker. This is one fault-line the rebel MLAs harped on relentlessly. Deepak Kesarkar, the outgoing finance minister and MLA from a Konkan constituency who joined Shinde's rebel camp, voiced it thus: "Uddhav joined the very people his sympathisers were fighting against. He didn't care about the sentiments of his own people."

RATHER THAN DEVELOP A CHANNEL OF NETWORKING WITH SAINIKS, UDDHAV CHOSE TO OUTSOURCE IT TO HIS SON, NEPHEW ET AL

And then, the inherent complications of alliance politics gradually worked their corrosive effect at two levels: one in the ideological field, owing to a stridently Hindutva party beginning to offer subtle dilutions of its brand; the other in the realm of realpolitik—a zone where someone like Pawar is always a cut above the rest. To start off, Uddhav's troubles with the BJP were *not* ideological either. They had to do with stark forms of power politics. Things began to sour soon after the assembly election results in October 2019, when Uddhav took strong objection to Fadnavis's claim that "nothing like sharing the CM's post with the Sena" was discussed between then BJP president Amit Shah and Uddhav. This week, Sanjay Raut claimed Uddhav had chosen Shinde as the CM, assuming the BJP would keep its promise. But that was no more than a desperate attempt to create confusion during the endgame. While what transpired between Shah and Uddhav in their one-to-one meeting lingers as a mystery, Uddhav clearly wanted the CM's chair for himself.

Shinde was in the thick of action in another way, though. It was he who proactively brought back two NCP MLAs to Pawar when his ambitious nephew, Ajit Pawar, had briefly rebelled to form the ill-fated government with Fadnavis. That particular government lasted only 78 hours, as Pawar Sr managed to abort and reverse the rebellion—this was the moment when Fadnavis's credibility was at its lowest. The common Sainik was as irate as the leadership, and wanted the BJP to be taught a lesson. So, when Uddhav waltzed across the ideological floor, joining hands with the Congress-NCP, the Sena cadre was actually—perhaps naively—happy for two reasons. They were back in power, and the BJP, which had proved itself unworthy of friendship, had been deposed. It smelt like sweet revenge. So there was scope to make things work.

But the perils of forming a government with Pawar—who many observers would unhesitatingly call the most untrustworthy politician from Maharashtra—were soon apparent. The NCP was only the second-largest party in the MVA—it had 53 MLAs, while the Sena initially had 56 (one death eventually trimmed that to 55). Yet, Pawar managed to secure four key portfolios for the NCP—finance, home, water resources and rural development. The partisan behaviour of the finance ministry, pocketed by Ajit Pawar, especially became a huge reason for discontent. Statistics shows almost 49 per cent of the state's funds were spent in constituencies won by the NCP. And Congress constituencies got 33 per cent. Sena's own areas got only a measly 17 per cent. When Sena MLAs cited this stepmotherly treatment to Uddhav, he asked then to mute their anger as his priority was to maintain cordial relations with the NCP. Ajit Pawar, on his part, claims he had no role in fund distribution. "It's the responsibility of the minister concerned to take care of a department's spending," he says.

The impoverishment at the level of finances soon spread to politics. The Sena lost almost every election it fought in association with the NCP-Congress—Shrikant Deshpande for the Amravati graduate councillor's post in 2021, and Sanjay Pawar the Rajya Sabha election this June. The most depressing moment for the cadre came when Uddhav opted to spare the Kolhapur assembly seat for the Congress. In 2019, the Congress's Chandrakant Jadhav had won it against the Sena's